Speaking Truth – A Collection

By Shel Silverstein, Barbara K. Bassett and Maya Angelou

The Voice by Shel Silverstein

There is a voice inside of you
that whispers all day long,
'I feel that this is right for me,
I know that this is wrong.'
No teacher, preacher, parent, friend
or wise man can decide
what's right for you - just listen to
the voice that speaks inside.

SOURCE INFORMATION

Author: Shel Silverstein
Book: Falling Up
ISBN: 978-0060248024
Publisher: HarperCollins
Date (Month/Year): Jan 2006

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INTRODUCTION

Henry David Thoreau once said, "We are constantly invited to be who we are." So why it is so difficult to find our voices, to speak our truth? Fear – we fear rejection, we fear judgment, we fear becoming assertive and powerful.

But perhaps Audre Lorde said it best: "The speaking will get easier and easier. . . And at last you'll know with surpassing certainty that only one thing is more frightening than speaking your truth. And that is not speaking."

Transformation - A Collection of Three Poems: The Voice by Shel Silverstein; Angela's Word by Barbara K. Bassett and On the Pulse of Morning by Maya Angelou

Angela's Word by Barbara K. Bassett

When Angela was very young, age two or three or so, her father and her mother taught her never to say "NO". They taught her that she must agree with everything they said, and if she didn't, she was spanked and sent upstairs to bed.

So Angela grew up to be a most agreeable child; she was never angry and she was never wild; she always shared, she always cared, she never picked a fight, and not matter what her parents said, she thought that they were right.

Angela the angel did very well in school. And, as you might imagine, she followed every rule; her teachers said she was well-bred, so quiet and so good, but how Angela felt inside they never understood.

Angela had lots of friends who liked her for her smile; they knew she was the kind of gal who'd go the extra mile; and even when she had a cold and really needed rest, when someone asked her if she'd help, she always answered "yes."

When Angela was thirty-three, she was a lawyer's wife. She had a home and family, a nice suburban life. She had a girl of four and a little boy of nine, and if someone asked her how she felt, she always answered, "Fine."

But one cold night near Christmastime when her family was in bed, she lay awake as awful thoughts went spinning through her head; she didn't know why, and she didn't know how, but she wanted her life to end; so she begged Whoever put her here to take her back again.

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And then she heard from deep inside, a voice that was soft and low; it only said a single word and the word it said was . . . NO."

From that moment on, Angela knew exactly what she had to do. Her life depended on that word, so this is what her loved ones heard:

"NO, I just don't want to; NO, I don't agree; NO, that's yours to handle; NO, that's wrong for me; NO, I wanted something else; NO, that hurt a lot! NO, I'm tired, and NO, I'm busy, and NO, I'd rather not!"

Well, her family found it shocking, her friends reacted with surprise; but Angela was different, you could see it in her eyes; for they've held no meek submission since that night three years ago when Angela the angel got permission to say NO.

Today Angela's a person first, then a mother and a wife. She knows where she begins and ends, she has a separate life. She has talents and ambitions, she has feelings, needs, and goals. She has money in the bank and an opinion at the polls.

And to her boy and girl she says, "It's nice when we agree; but if you can't say 'NO', you'll never grow to be all you're meant to be. Because I know I'm sometimes wrong and because I love you so, you'll always be my angels even when you tell me 'NO.'

SOURCE INFORMATION

Author: Barbara K Bassett
Book: Chicken Soup for the Woman's Soul: Stories to Open the Heart and Rekindle the Spirit of Women
ISBN: 978-1623610432
Publisher: Backlist, LLC
Date (Month/Year): Aug 2012

TRANSITION

And so as individuals we find our voices; but we too must listen. Listen to the truth of those around us. Listen to the still quiet words of nature. Maya Angelou provides hope and gives voice to the quiet truth of . . . . (Start first line of the following poem here)

On the Pulse of Morning by Maya Angelou

A Rock, A River, A Tree
Hosts to species long since departed,
Marked the mastodon,
The dinosaur, who left dried tokens

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Of their sojourn here
On our planet floor,
Any broad alarm of their hastening doom
Is lost in the gloom of dust and ages.

But today, the Rock cries out to us, clearly, forcefully,
Come, you may stand upon my
Back and face your distant destiny,
But seek no haven in my shadow.
I will give you no hiding place down here.

You, created only a little lower than
The angels, have crouched too long in
The bruising darkness
Have lain too long
Face down in ignorance.
Your mouths spilling words

Armed for slaughter.
The Rock cries out to us today, you may stand upon me,
But do not hide your face.

Across the wall of the world,
A River sings a beautiful song. It says,
Come, rest here by my side.

Each of you, a bordered country,
Delicate and strangely made proud,
Yet thrusting perpetually under siege.
Your armed struggles for profit
Have left collars of waste upon
My shore, currents of debris upon my breast.
Yet today I call you to my riverside,
If you will study war no more. Come,
Clad in peace, and I will sing the songs
The Creator gave to me when I and the
Tree and the rock were one.
Before cynicism was a bloody sear across your
Brow and when you yet knew you still
Knew nothing.
The River sang and sings on.

There is a true yearning to respond to
The singing River and the wise Rock.
So say the Asian, the Hispanic, the Jew
The African, the Native American, the Sioux,
The Catholic, the Muslim, the French, the Greek
The Irish, the Rabbi, the Priest, the Sheik,
The Gay, the Straight, the Preacher,

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The privileged, the homeless, the Teacher.
They hear. They all hear
The speaking of the Tree.

They hear the first and last of every Tree
Speak to humankind today. Come to me, here beside the River.
Plant yourself beside the River.

Each of you, descendant of some passed
On traveller, has been paid for.
You, who gave me my first name, you,
Pawnee, Apache, Seneca, you
Cherokee Nation, who rested with me, then
Forced on bloody feet,
Left me to the employment of
Other seekers—desperate for gain,
Starving for gold.
You, the Turk, the Arab, the Swede, the German, the Eskimo, the Scot,
You the Ashanti, the Yoruba, the Kru, bought,
Sold, stolen, arriving on the nightmare
Praying for a dream.

Here, root yourselves beside me.
I am that Tree planted by the River,
Which will not be moved.
I, the Rock, I the River, I the Tree
I am yours—your passages have been paid.
Lift up your faces, you have a piercing need
For this bright morning dawning for you.
History, despite its wrenching pain
Cannot be unlived, but if faced
With courage, need not be lived again.

Lift up your eyes upon
This day breaking for you.
Give birth again
To the dream.

Women, children, men,
Take it into the palms of your hands,
Mold it into the shape of your most
Private need. Sculpt it into
The image of your most public self.
Lift up your hearts
Each new hour holds new chances

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For a new beginning.
Do not be wedded forever
To fear, yoked eternally
To brutishness.

The horizon leans forward,
Offering you space to place new steps of change.
Here, on the pulse of this fine day
You may have the courage
To look up and out and upon me, the
Rock, the River, the Tree, your country.
No less to Midas than the mendicant.
No less to you now than the mastodon then.

Here, on the pulse of this new day
You may have the grace to look up and out
And into your sister's eyes, and into
Your brother's face, your country
And say simply
Very simply
With hope—
Good morning.

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SOURCE INFORMATION

Author: Maya Angelou
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AWARD HISTORY

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